used to in France.

An idea came to Rose. Every night, the bulbs at the barracks flickered, signaling the start of another blackout. Maybe she could take one or two candles from the pile so she could continue drawing while Léa studied German, though her sister insisted she study to improve her German, too. With so many candles stacked in the box, she didn't think one or two would be missed.

She looked around. Rose was alone in the church. She stood, went to the corner and took two candles from the box. Suddenly, a creaking sound froze her. Had someone entered? *Thud*. Panic ripped through her chest—the door had opened and shut. Footsteps clacked on the tiled floor, coming closer. Should she put the candles back, or was it too late? She sensed a presence beside her.

"Excuse me, I thought no one would be here," a man's voice said.

Rose turned, throat tight. She'd been in Germany long enough to know what the black diamond "SD" insignia on the man's sleeve meant. A Security Service officer—Gestapo—in a field-gray uniform stood before her. Rose's heart pounded as she struggled to stay calm.

"Where are you from?" He glanced at her apron and the candles in her hand.

"France." Her voice shook with fear. She braced herself for a slap across the face or something worse, if he accused her of stealing as Madame Martin had.

"You are also here to make a prayer?"

Her thoughts scrambled. A prayer?

"It's not our tradition to light votive candles and place them before altars or shrines as in your country."

She looked down at the candles, trying to steady her trembling fingers. "I'm sorry." She looked up. His eyes pinned her. She wanted to run, but his gaze held her in a vise, and she had to wait for him to let her go.

"Since we're both in mourning—" he sighed "—you're forgiven." His voice took on a melancholy tone. "Perhaps I shall join you. Would you like that?"

"Yes," she stuttered.

"Don't be afraid. We're allies; our countries are on the same side." He removed one of the candles from her hand. "Isn't that why you're here, to